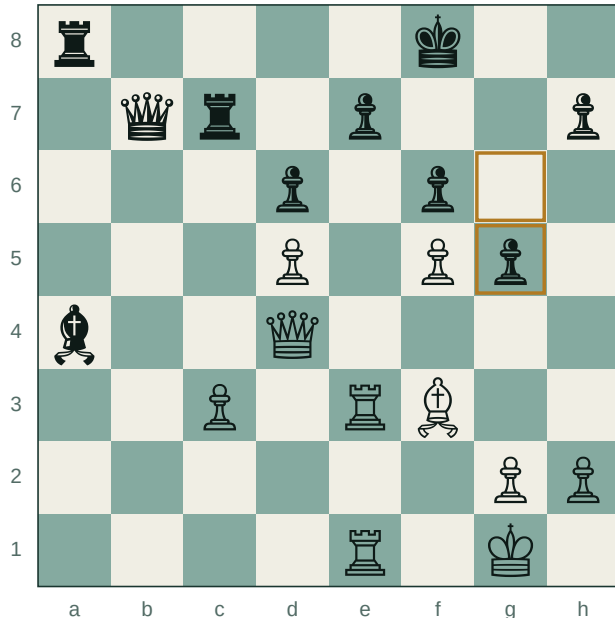


Capture the defender: White, move 30

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 29...g5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

30. Rxe7 Rxe7 31. Qxf6+

30.Rxe7 The rook captures the pawn on e7. Recorded reply: **30...Rxe7**.

31.Qxf6+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From f6 it attacks king on f8 and rook on e7.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -3: the balance goes from +0 to -3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on f8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.